11.1 Resonance

WORKSHEET

The question

STEP II 1991, Question 12

Read the question before you go on. It is in the STEP Support Programme's question database:

step.maths.org/questions/91-s2-q12

Hints

Try the question on your own first. If you get stuck, read the hints *one at a time*, and go back to the question after each one. Hints marked *Pause and try* are the key steps.

Ask yourself The particle hangs in equilibrium with extension c. If the string has modulus λ, what is the relation between λ, a, c, m and g? What is the extension when the top has moved down by $b\sin pt$ and the particle by x?

STAGE 2 Solving

Ask yourself The equation is $\ddot{x} + n^2x = n^2b\sin pt$. Try a particular solution of the form $x = C\sin pt$. Then add the general solution of $\ddot{x} + n^2x = 0$. Which initial conditions does the particle satisfy?

STAGE 3 Staying taut

Ask yourself The string is taut exactly when its extension is positive. Write the extension $c + x - b\sin pt$ in terms of t.

Ask yourself How negative can $p\sin pt - n\sin nt$ possibly be?

Pause and try What happens to this condition as p approaches n? How small must the shaking amplitude b be when $p = 0.9n$? When $p = 0.99n$?

Try this next

1. **A falling lift.** Try STEP II 1996, Question 11 (step.maths.org/questions/96-s2-q11): a mass on an elastic string in a lift that starts and then stops accelerating. Watch how the final amplitude depends on how long the acceleration lasts.

2. **At resonance.** Solve $\ddot{x} + n^2x = n^2b\sin nt$ with $x(0) = \dot{x}(0) = 0$ directly, by trying a particular solution $x = Ct\cos nt$. Check that it agrees with the limit above.

3. **Beats.** Show that $n\sin pt - p\sin nt$ can be written as a sum of two terms, one of which is approximately $2n\cos\frac{(n+p)t}{2}\sin\frac{(p-n)t}{2}$ when p is close to n. Hence explain the beat period $\frac{2\pi}{n-p}$.

4. **Damped resonance.** For $\ddot{x} + 2k\dot{x} + n^2x = F\cos pt$ with small $k > 0$, find the steady-state amplitude, and show that it is greatest when $p^2 = n^2 - 2k^2$.

Further reading

- **A. P. French, *Vibrations and Waves*** (MIT Introductory Physics Series). Chapter 4 on forced oscillations and resonance is the classic account.
- **Steven Strogatz, *Sync*** (Penguin). How things fall into step, from fireflies to the Millennium Bridge.
- **Henry Petroski, *To Engineer Is Human*** (Vintage). Engineering failures, including the bridges in the history box.

The full guided solution, and what the question leads to at university, is in Section 11.1:
https://beyondstep.keithmcnulty.org/ch11/resonance.html